



Hack for Humanity Playbook

Purpose: A reusable operating playbook for AI Collective communities hosting MLH Hack Days.

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Add headings to create a table of contents. [Learn more](#).

▼ The operating model

An MLH Hack Day is an entirely in-person mini-hackathon lasting 12 hours or less. Events as short as four hours may be approved. The program is designed to be lighter-weight than a weekend hackathon: MLH provides OrganizerHQ, an opening-ceremony deck, swag, partner prizes, and eligible expense reimbursements.

For our community, each event should have six named owners:

Owner	Accountable for
Event lead	MLH application, partner choice, venue/date approval, MLH contact
Operations lead	Venue, accessibility, Wi-Fi/power/AV, food, swag, check-in desk, emergency plan
Program lead	Schedule, mentors, opening/closing, workshops, judging, partner challenge
Community/comms lead	Registration page, outreach, reminder emails, attendee channel
Finance lead	Budget, itemized receipts, Ramp submission, reimbursement tracking
Media/evidence lead	Photos, event summary, project export, post-event evidence package

One person may hold multiple roles, but every responsibility should have an explicit owner.

▼ Non-negotiable MLH requirements

- Apply through [OrganizerHQ](#), ideally 4-8 weeks before the event. MLH says 3-4 weeks is the minimum recommended lead time; its planning timeline targets at least one month.
- Keep the event entirely in person and 12 hours or less. No hybrid participation, virtual preliminary rounds, or other virtual event components beyond registration and check-in.
- Use OrganizerHQ for registration and event-day check-ins. Reimbursement is based on checked-in attendees, not registrations.
- Use OrganizerHQ for project submissions and winner administration unless MLH explicitly tells us otherwise for a specific event.
- Distribute all shipped MLH and partner swag and prizes.
- Present the MLH-provided 2-5 minute recorded content during the opening ceremony using the partner-specific deck.
- Collect projects, judge the assigned partner category, announce winners, and distribute all prizes. Raffle extras or use them for a second-place award.
- After the event, provide MLH with photos, an event summary, project submission data, and all purchase receipts.
- Follow the [MLH Code of Conduct](#), institutional safety rules, visitor policies, accessibility requirements, and any rules for minors.

▼ Reusable planning timeline

▼ 4-8 weeks before

- ☐ Define the audience, theme, expected headcount, date, and a 4-12 hour event window.
- ☐ Choose a requested partner, understanding MLH may assign a different partner and the roster can change.
- ☐ Confirm partner eligibility before advertising:
 - **Google Gemini:** broad program, but the GitHub page says Gemini attendees must be 18 or older. Confirm this with MLH and enforce it if assigned.
 - **Snowflake:** limited US alpha pilot for roughly five organizers; availability is not guaranteed.
 - **GitHub Copilot:** US high-school organizers only.
- ☐ Submit the OrganizerHQ application.
- ☐ Reserve an accessible venue with reliable attendee Wi-Fi, sufficient outlets, chairs, a projector/screen, and working audio. Plan tables for check-in/swag and food.
- ☐ Confirm fire-code capacity, visitor access, insurance/campus policy, minors' permissions if applicable, and a faculty/staff point of contact.
- ☐ Start outreach to a broad, inclusive audience; recruit mentors and judges.

▼ 2-3 weeks before

- ☐ Publish the OrganizerHQ registration page with exact start/end time, specific location, contact email, event description, and food/beverage details.
- ☐ Draft the run of show, including check-in, opening, hacking, workshops or mentor office hours, meals, submission deadline, judging, demos, prizes, and closing.
- ☐ Confirm the project-submission workflow in the event's MLH onboarding packet.
- ☐ Copy the correct opening deck:
 - [Google Gemini deck](#)
 - [Snowflake deck](#)
 - [GitHub deck](#)
- ☐ Customize the deck: event title/location/date; organizer name, photo, organization, and fun facts (slide 3); community name/logo/about text (slide 22); schedule (slide 23); attendee channel (slide 24); project-submission link (slide 25); OrganizerHQ check-in link (slide 26); and assigned prizes/partners (slide 27 onward).
- ☐ Send the first reminder around three weeks before.
- ☐ Shortlist food vendors and estimate food using expected attendance, not raw registrations.

▼ 7 days before

- ☐ Finalize the realistic headcount; reimbursements cover no more than 50 checked-in hackers.
- ☐ Confirm the food order 3-7 days ahead. Include plates, utensils, napkins, dietary coverage, and non-alcoholic drinks—or tell attendees to bring refillable bottles.
- ☐ Confirm who will receive, transport, inventory, and distribute the MLH swag pack.
- ☐ Test the opening deck, embedded videos, sound, projector, every QR code, and every event link.
- ☐ Verify the check-in QR code especially carefully: it directly controls reimbursement eligibility.
- ☐ Confirm mentors, judges, judging rubric, partner-usage verification, emergency plan, photographer, and photo permissions/consent process.
- ☐ Send the one-week reminder with logistics, schedule, preparation steps, Code of Conduct, food details, and what to bring.

► Day before

▼ Day-of runbook

▼ Setup

- ☐ Test Wi-Fi, outlets, projector, audio, and embedded videos.
- ☐ Set up a clear check-in/swag table and separate food area.
- ☐ Display OrganizerHQ check-in and attendee-community QR codes.
- ☐ Confirm the submission deadline, judging window, judging access, and prize inventory.

▼ Opening ceremony

- ☐ Welcome attendees and introduce our organizers/community.
- ☐ Show the MLH-provided recorded content; do not rewrite slides covered by the embedded videos.
- ☐ Explain the schedule, Code of Conduct, support/mentor model, food, attendee channel, submission deadline, judging, and prizes.
- ☐ Make everyone complete OrganizerHQ check-in.
- ☐ Explain the assigned partner challenge and what constitutes valid use.

▼ Hacking period

- ☐ Help attendees form teams, scope achievable projects, and find mentors.
- ☐ Keep partner resources visible; remind teams that judges will verify actual product/API use.
- ☐ Distribute meals based on checked-in attendance and retain full itemized receipts.
- ☐ Distribute general swag; reserve "I Demoed" stickers for people who present projects.
- ☐ Photograph collaboration, demos, community branding, MLH/partner branding, mini-events, diverse participation, and opening/closing moments.
- ☐ Avoid photos of sleeping attendees, messy food-covered workstations, shoes-off scenes, close-up headshots, or filtered images.

▼ Submissions, judging, and closing

- ☐ Require project name, description, repository, and technologies used.
- ☐ Export submissions in OrganizerHQ via **Registrations → Export Challenge Submissions**; OrganizerHQ emails the organizer a CSV.
- ☐ Verify eligibility and partner usage before scoring.
- ☐ Announce winners, distribute every physical prize, and record winner/project details. MLH may issue some prizes as post-event digital gift cards.
- ☐ Thank attendees, mentors, judges, volunteers, the venue, MLH, and the assigned partner.

▼ Partner-specific implementation

- ▶ Google Gemini
- ▶ Snowflake
- ▶ GitHub Copilot

▼ Budget and reimbursement controls

- US allowance: up to **USD 7 per checked-in hacker**, capped at **50 hackers / USD 350 total**.
- International rates differ by country and are listed in the guide using purchasing-power parity.
- MLH reimburses actual eligible spending only; unused allowance is not paid out.
- Meals, snacks, and non-alcoholic beverages are always reimbursable.
- Get written approval from hackdays@mlh.io before committing to other expense categories. Exorbitant prize or swag costs may be rejected.
- Keep full itemized receipts and a simple ledger mapping each purchase to the event.
- Submit through Ramp after MLH sends the invitation. The guide says reimbursement typically takes about 30 days, with possible variation.

Recommended budget formula:

`spend ceiling = min(checked-in attendees, 50) x applicable country rate`

Do not spend against registered headcount. Build a conservative food order from expected attendance and keep a small operational buffer within the ceiling.

▼ Post-event evidence package

Complete within 24-48 hours while details are fresh:

- ☐ OrganizerHQ check-in count
- ☐ OrganizerHQ project-submission CSV
- ☐ Winners, project links, and partner-usage verification
- ☐ Curated event photos, including MLH and partner branding
- ☐ Short event summary: turnout, schedule, outcomes, highlights, issues, and improvements
- ☐ Itemized receipts plus expense ledger
- ☐ Attendee/organizer feedback and lessons for the next event
- ☐ Confirmation that all prizes and swag were distributed

Track the Ramp submission until reimbursement arrives.

▼ Questions to send MLH once an event is approved

1. Which partner is assigned, and what are the final challenge copy, prize, judging requirements, and deck?
2. Is OrganizerHQ the only required project-submission system, or is Devpost also required?
3. Does the assigned Gemini event require every attendee to be 18+?
4. What is this event's exact country reimbursement rate and Ramp workflow?
5. When should the swag pack arrive, and who is the shipment contact?
6. Are any proposed non-food expenses pre-approved?

▼ Completeness record: all 16 pages reviewed

1. [About Hack Days](#)
2. [Frequently Asked Questions](#)
3. [Event Planning Guide](#)
4. [So You're Thinking About Organizing a Hack Day](#)
5. [Hack Day Planning Timeline](#)
6. [Project Submissions and Judging](#)
7. [Photography](#)
8. [Hack Day Guide for School Administrators](#)
9. [Opening Ceremony Guide](#)
10. [Project Submissions at Hack Days](#)
11. [Swag](#)
12. [Reimbursements](#)
13. [Partner Details](#)
14. [Google Gemini](#)
15. [Snowflake](#)
16. [GitHub Copilot](#)